



ULAB
UNIVERSITY OF LIBERAL ARTS
BANGLADESH

Emergency Communications Plan for Flood Response in Chattogram and Feni

Course code: MSJ 3263

Course Title: Emergency Communication

Section: 01

Semester: Fall 2024

Submitted to: Md. Aminul Islam,
Senior Lecturer, School of Social Sciences

Submitted by:

Zamiul Haque (222012028)
Ahsan Habib (222012024)
Md. Sad Bin Abbas Sanim (222012034)

Submission Date: 06/01/2025

Emergency Communications Plan for Flood Response in Chattogram and Feni

Prepared for: Chattogram City Corporation

Prepared by: Emergency Communications Consultant

Dynamic Listening and Rumor Management

Processes for Monitoring Social Media and Other Channels:

Monitoring social media and communication channels is critical to identifying rumors and misinformation during an emergency. A dedicated team should be set up to track real-time activities on platforms like Facebook, Twitter, WhatsApp, and local forums. Using monitoring tools such as Hootsuite, Brandwatch, or Google Alerts can help in tracking keywords, hashtags, and discussions relevant to the flood situation in Chattogram and Feni. Partnering with local media outlets, NGOs, and community organizations ensures the collection of on-ground insights and addresses misinformation effectively.

Strategies for Addressing Harmful Rumors:

A proactive approach to rumor management is essential. Establishing an "Emergency Fact Check" portal where verified updates are consistently shared can serve as the foundation. Rapid-response teams should post corrections to false claims directly on popular platforms. Collaboration with community leaders, influencers, and trusted local figures can amplify the reach of accurate information. For persistent misinformation, using public service announcements via radio or television can further dispel rumors and reduce panic.

Public Engagement Through Dynamic Listening:

Dynamic listening involves actively engaging with the community to understand their concerns and directly combat misinformation. Hosting live question-and-answer sessions on platforms like Facebook Live or through local radio channels allows for transparent communication. Setting up community-based WhatsApp groups or SMS alert systems provides an accessible, two-way communication channel.

Regular surveys and feedback mechanisms can also gauge public sentiment, which helps refine messaging and ensures the community feels heard and supported.

Spokesperson Role and Responsibilities

Public Speaking Skills: The ability to communicate clearly and confidently in high-pressure situations, often addressing large audiences through live broadcasts, press briefings, or community meetings.

Emotional Intelligence: An empathetic approach to delivering messages, recognizing the fear, anxiety, and confusion often present during emergencies. This builds trust and reassurance among the affected population.

Cultural Awareness: Familiarity with local customs, languages, and community dynamics to ensure messages resonate with diverse audiences.

Expertise in Crisis Communication: A deep understanding of the principles and protocols of emergency communication, including familiarity with best practices and ethical considerations.

Credibility and Authority: The spokesperson must inspire trust and be seen as a reliable source of information, maintaining alignment with official emergency response teams.

Spokesperson Training Protocols

To effectively prepare a spokesperson for their role, comprehensive training programs must address technical skills, psychological readiness, and real-world scenario planning. These include:

Media Training: Focused on developing skills for handling live interviews, press conferences, and responding to journalists' questions. The training also includes strategies to remain calm under intense scrutiny and techniques to avoid misstatements.

Message Development: Training on how to craft concise, consistent, and impactful messages. Spokespersons are taught to align their statements with the overall emergency response strategy, ensuring coherence across communication channels.

Simulated Emergency Scenarios: Regular role-playing exercises simulate high-pressure situations, such as handling misinformation about evacuation protocols or responding to criticism from affected communities. These scenarios help build confidence and preparedness.

Stress Management Techniques: Being the face of a crisis can be emotionally taxing. Spokespersons are trained in mindfulness, breathing techniques, and other methods to maintain composure during extended emergencies.

Duties of the Spokesperson

Before an Emergency

Building Relationships: Establishing connections with media outlets, community leaders, and stakeholders to ensure smoother coordination during emergencies.

Familiarization with Protocols: Reviewing the emergency communication plan, understanding the crisis command structure, and identifying approved communication channels.

Community Outreach: Participating in awareness campaigns that inform residents about reliable sources of information, how to report issues, and emergency protocols.

Media Monitoring: Working with monitoring teams to identify trends in misinformation or public sentiment that may require preemptive communication.

During an Emergency

Timely Updates: Regularly disseminating updates about the situation's status, such as flood progression, evacuation notices, or resource availability. Updates should be concise, fact-based, and easy to understand.

Misinformation Management: Actively countering rumors and misinformation through verified facts. This may involve directly addressing false claims during press conferences or on social media.

Public Engagement: Hosting live Q&A sessions or community briefings to address public concerns, dispel fears, and provide actionable advice.

Coordinated Messaging: Ensuring all messages are aligned with the official narrative, working closely with the Emergency Communications Command Center (ECCC) to prevent conflicting information.

Reassuring Presence: Remaining calm and empathetic, demonstrating that the situation is under control and that response efforts are effective.

After an Emergency

Recovery Communication: Providing updates on relief efforts, such as the distribution of aid, restoration of infrastructure, or return of displaced residents to their homes.

Recognition of Efforts: Publicly acknowledging the contributions of emergency workers, volunteers, NGOs, and local government in managing the crisis.

Evaluation and Reporting: Participating in post-crisis evaluations to assess the effectiveness of the communication strategy. These evaluations identify lessons learned and inform future improvements.

Transparency and Accountability: Sharing detailed reports about response efforts, including successes and challenges, to maintain public trust.

Coordination with Response Personnel

Centralized Command: Working under the ECCC, the spokesperson ensures alignment with the overarching strategy of the emergency response team.

Real-Time Updates: Receiving ongoing briefings from field personnel, government agencies, and other stakeholders to ensure messages reflect the current situation accurately.

Collaborative Decision-Making: Collaborating with senior officials to approve and prioritize messages, ensuring critical updates reach the public promptly.

Integration with Technology Teams: Partnering with social media and digital communication teams to amplify the reach of official updates and counter misinformation effectively.

Challenges and Mitigation Strategies

Support Teams: Establishing a dedicated support team to assist with fact-checking, message drafting, and logistical arrangements during press briefings.

Crisis-Specific Protocols: Creating message templates for common scenarios, such as evacuation orders or flood warnings, to expedite the communication process.

Feedback Loops: Incorporating community feedback into updates to address public concerns and improve transparency.

Message Development and Materials

Clarity: Use plain language to convey information. Avoid jargon and technical terms. For example, instead of saying "precipitation-induced inundation," use "flooding due to heavy rain." Clarity reduces confusion, particularly during high-stress situations.

Conciseness: Emergency messages should be brief and direct, focusing on what the audience must know and do. Long-winded explanations can lead to misinterpretation or important details being overlooked.

Accuracy: Every message must be fact-checked and verified to avoid misinformation. This ensures public trust and minimizes the spread of rumors.

Empathy and Reassurance: Acknowledge the audience's fears and concerns while offering guidance and support. Statements like "We understand this is a challenging time, and we are here to support you" build trust and cooperation.

Accessibility: Adapt messages to suit diverse audiences, including those with limited literacy, disabilities, or language barriers. Consider audio formats, subtitles, and visuals like infographics for better reach.

Templates and Examples for Common Message Types

Updates: "Flood waters have reached critical levels in [specific area]. Authorities are closely monitoring the situation and deploying resources. Residents are advised to prepare for potential evacuation. Stay tuned for updates via [official channel]."

Warnings: "Alert: Rising water levels in [river/area] pose a risk of flash flooding. Avoid low-lying areas and proceed to designated shelters at [locations]. Follow official instructions and call [emergency hotline] for assistance."

Closures: "Notice: Due to ongoing flooding, [name of roads/bridges/schools] will remain closed until further notice. Alternative routes include [details]. For updates, visit [website]."

Resource Availability: "Relief supplies, including food and drinking water, are available at [distribution center]. Assistance for medical needs is accessible at [specific location]. Contact [helpline number] for more details."

Processes for Rapid Message Creation, Vetting, Translation, and Dissemination

Creation: Pre-develop templates for various scenarios such as natural disasters, public health emergencies, or infrastructure failures. This allows responders to rapidly customize messages. Collaborate with subject matter experts to ensure accuracy and relevance during message drafting.

Vetting: Implement a tiered approval process where senior leaders, communication specialists, and legal advisors review messages for consistency with policies and accuracy. Use a "rapid-response" protocol for urgent situations, ensuring messages are validated within minutes.

Translation: Employ professional translators or reliable tools to provide messages in multiple languages, reflective of the community's diversity. Conduct quality checks to ensure translations maintain the original intent and clarity.

Dissemination: Leverage multiple channels to reach the broadest audience. These include SMS alerts, email notifications, social media updates, public service announcements (PSAs) on TV and radio, and traditional print materials.

Adaptation for Diverse Audiences and Channels

Digital Channels: Utilize social media platforms like Facebook, Twitter, and Instagram for real-time updates, using hashtags for visibility. Include visual aids like maps, infographics, or short videos to clarify complex information.

Broadcast Media: Partner with local TV and radio stations for live announcements and scheduled updates. These channels are essential for reaching areas with limited internet access.

Print Media: Distribute flyers, posters, and pamphlets in neighborhoods with high foot traffic. Use bold headlines, simple language, and visuals for quick comprehension.

Community Networks: Collaborate with local leaders, NGOs, and community organizations to disseminate information through trusted grassroots channels.

Accessibility for Vulnerable Populations: Provide content in Braille or audio formats for visually impaired individuals. Ensure sign language interpreters are available during live broadcasts for the hearing impaired. Simplify messaging for those with low literacy levels, relying on visuals or pictograms.

Feedback Integration: Incorporate feedback mechanisms such as helpline numbers or online forms where the public can ask questions or report issues. This fosters two-way communication and enhances the relevance of subsequent updates.

Proposed Implementation Plan for the Emergency Communications Plan

Defining Roles and Responsibilities:

Clear delineation of tasks ensures that every team member knows their specific role. For example:

- **Spokesperson:** Handles public communication and media interactions.
- **Monitoring Team:** Tracks social media, news, and public sentiment.
- **Message Creation Team:** Drafts and approves updates and advisories.
- **Dissemination Team:** Distributes messages through predefined channels.

Resource Allocation:

Secure the necessary tools and infrastructure, such as communication software, real-time data dashboards, and multilingual translation services. Allocate funds for community outreach programs and media partnerships.

Developing Protocols:

Create standard operating procedures (SOPs) for all communication activities, including:

- Message approval workflows.
- Escalation procedures for critical issues.
- Processes for addressing misinformation.

Stakeholder Engagement:

Collaborate with local government, media outlets, NGOs, and community leaders to ensure seamless coordination during emergencies. Conduct pre-incident meetings to align goals and expectations.

Community Awareness Campaigns:

Launch proactive campaigns to educate the public on emergency procedures, trusted information sources, and how to report issues. These efforts reduce panic and enhance cooperation during actual crises.

Designing Training Programs for Emergency Communication Roles

Training is vital to ensure that all personnel can perform their duties effectively under pressure. A comprehensive training program includes:

1. Foundational Training:

Provide basic training on emergency communication principles, crisis management, and community engagement to all team members. Cover topics such as message creation, cultural sensitivity, and ethical considerations.

2. Role-Specific Training:

Tailor training modules for specific roles:

- **Spokespersons:** Media handling, public speaking, and managing difficult questions.
- **Social Media Teams:** Monitoring trends, countering misinformation, and using analytics tools.
- **Dissemination Teams:** Leveraging multiple channels and ensuring accessibility.

3. Technical Skill Development:

Train teams to use specialized tools like crisis management software, GIS mapping for localized messaging, and translation software for multilingual communication.

4. Simulated Crisis Drills:

Conduct regular simulations to mimic real-world scenarios. For instance:

- Managing the spread of misinformation during a flood.
- Coordinating messages for a sudden evacuation order. These exercises help identify gaps in the plan and improve response times.

5. Psychological Preparedness:

Equip staff with stress management techniques and coping mechanisms to handle the emotional toll of crisis work. Offer counseling services if needed.

6. Continuous Education:

Schedule periodic refresher courses and workshops to keep teams updated on new technologies, strategies, and challenges in emergency communication.

Recommendations for Periodic Testing and Simulation Exercises

1. Tabletop Exercises:

These low-pressure discussions simulate hypothetical emergency scenarios. Participants walk through their roles and responsibilities, fostering familiarity with protocols.

2. Full-Scale Drills:

Conduct comprehensive simulations involving all stakeholders, including emergency responders, government agencies, and community representatives. For example:

- Simulate a flood situation in a vulnerable district like Chittagong or Feni.
- Test the dissemination of evacuation orders and resource allocation updates.

3. Feedback Mechanisms:

After each simulation, conduct debriefing sessions to gather insights from participants. Use this feedback to refine protocols and address identified gaps.

4. Technology Testing:

Regularly test communication tools, such as SMS alert systems, mobile apps, and social media platforms, to ensure functionality during an actual emergency.

5. Community Involvement:

Engage local communities in drills to familiarize them with emergency procedures and communication channels. This builds trust and reduces panic during real events.

6. Annual Evaluations:

Schedule a yearly review of the Emergency Communications Plan to incorporate lessons from past incidents, advancements in technology, and changing community needs.